

The Body is the Unit:

Migrant Commodification Through Deportation, Detention, and Transnational Carceral Exchange

Bodies move across the tarmac. Guards flank the line as officials check manifests. The count must be precise: 252 Venezuelan bodies boarding the aircraft, each one verified, each one accounted for. This is July 18, 2025, and these men are being exchanged. 252 Venezuelans for ten American citizens and permanent residents held in Venezuela. The exchange ratio, 25 to 1, has been negotiated through diplomatic channels. Each body crossing this tarmac represents calculable currency in an international transaction.

Four months earlier, these same men had been involuntarily deported from the United States to El Salvador's Terrorism Confinement Center (CECOT), a maximum-security mega-prison. The U.S. government paid El Salvador \$6 million for annual detention capacity. Video footage of the exchange served no operational purpose; efficient prisoner exchanges occur without cameras. The theatrical display generates value: President Nayib Bukele extracts political capital from demonstrating control over bodies; the Trump administration secures visual proof of aggressive enforcement. The same migrant bodies produce value for both governments simultaneously.

This scene reveals the ultimate logic of contemporary U.S. immigration enforcement: migrant bodies functioning as tradable commodities whose circulation generates extractable value across multiple simultaneous markets.

Introduction

Contemporary U.S. immigration enforcement operates as a spatial governance regime that extracts calculable value from migrant bodies through strategic territorial positioning. This article develops a theoretical framework for understanding what we term migrant body commodification: the process through which state actors convert migrants' physical bodies into quantifiable units of extractable value via calculated spatial manipulation across local, national, and transnational scales. While migration scholars have extensively documented mechanisms through which migrants generate value for receiving states (Coddington et al., 2020; Hiemstra, 2024; Martin, 2020; Vogt, 2013), this literature has not fully theorized how spatial positioning of embodied migrants functions as the fundamental mechanism enabling value extraction across multiple domains.

Existing work on deportability and illegality, while illuminating extraction mechanisms, has not systematically theorized how spatial manipulation of embodied migrants constitutes the primary technology through which extraction becomes possible. This article addresses that gap by analyzing three distinct cases of state-sanctioned spatial commodification: Texas Governor Greg Abbott's systematic interstate busing operations (2022-2024), Florida Governor Ron DeSantis's spectacle migrant flight operations (2022-2023), and the Trump administration's CECOT transnational detention arrangement (2025). These cases reveal how different enforcement modalities extract distinct but complementary forms of value through strategic spatial positioning of migrant bodies rendered exploitable through legal precarity.

The three cases demonstrate commodification's optimization flexibility across radically different operational architectures. Abbott's systematic approach, resembling index fund investing in financial markets, extracts sustained political capital through volume processing of migrant bodies across multiple cities. DeSantis's spectacle model, operating like options trading, pursues extraordinary per-capita returns through concentrated symbolic targeting when political market conditions align favorably. The CECOT arrangement functions like complex derivatives, enabling simultaneous extraction across diplomatic, political, deterrent, and exchange value streams through manufactured jurisdictional complexity.

This analysis proceeds in five parts. First, we trace how migrant body commodification theory extends existing frameworks of spatial governance, carceral-spatial geography, and deportability. Second, we examine Abbott's systematic commodification model and its territorial logistics. Third, we analyze DeSantis's spectacle commodification and its dependence on symbolic spatial disruption. Fourth, we investigate the CECOT transnational arrangement's multi-scalar value extraction operating across jurisdictional boundaries. Finally, we synthesize across cases to theorize the spatial governance rationality organizing contemporary enforcement around migrant body commodification.

Spatial Governance and Migrant Body Commodification: Theoretical Foundations

Analysis of contemporary immigration enforcement as spatial governance requires theoretical frameworks capable of explaining how state power extracts value from strategic territorial positioning of human mobility. While migration scholars have extensively documented mechanisms through which migrants generate economic, political, and symbolic capital for receiving states, this literature has not fully theorized how spatial manipulation of migrant bodies functions as the primary technology enabling extraction across diverse value domains. This section traces how a theory of state-sanctioned migrant body commodification builds on and extends existing frameworks from carceral-spatial geography, border studies, and critical work on deportability.

Spatial Governance Through Legal Precarity

Legal exclusion from citizenship enables spatial governance by rendering certain bodies available for involuntary territorial manipulation (Balibar, 2004; Bosniak, 2006). The state cannot bus citizens from Texas to New York to serve gubernatorial political objectives because citizenship confers rights against such spatial instrumentalization. Citizenship creates the fundamental division of contemporary liberal democracies between populations protected against forced mobility and those rendered available for appropriation through spatial positioning by state power.

Nicholas De Genova's foundational theorization establishes that unauthorized status is not natural but a deliberately produced legal condition serving specific governmental functions (De Genova, 2002). Illegality operates as "a spatialized and typically racialized social condition" manufactured through law, producing populations simultaneously essential to capitalist economies yet systematically excluded from legal protections (De Genova, 2002, p. 439). This functions through what De Genova terms the "spectacle of enforcement": highly visible border policing and deportation operations that construct migrants as threats while ensuring their continued availability as labor. The deportation regime's real function is creating deportability, a condition of enforced vulnerability that renders migrants tractable and exploitable. State power functions not through excluding migrants but through including them under conditions of systematic legal precarity, with dramatic enforcement spectacles masking that unauthorized migrants constitute a permanent feature of the U.S.

labor market, disciplined into accepting substandard conditions precisely through their deportability (De Genova, 2002; Hiemstra, 2024).

From Illegality to Value Extraction

Building on De Genova's foundation, migration scholars have examined how illegality enables diverse value extraction. Coddington, Conlon and Martin (2020) propose destitution economies, arguing migrants become valuable through "uncertain status, dependence, and extreme impoverishments" that can be capitalized on (p. 1439). Martin and Tazzioli (2023) demonstrate how this operates through data production, unpaid 'voluntary' labor programs, and financialized accommodation schemes. Achtnich (2022) illustrates 'accumulation by immobilization' in Libya, showing how migrants' spatial containment generates extractable value.

Nancy Hiemstra's work on Venezuelan migrants in Ecuador provides sophisticated analysis of how illegality functions as value creation operating through both economic exploitation and sociopolitical legitimation (Hiemstra, 2024). Venezuelan migrants provide cheap flexible labor while generating fees through housing and service needs despite lacking legal authorization. Politically, their visible poverty legitimizes neoliberal governance by providing evidence that generous policies attract undeserving migrants, justifying austerity measures. Crucially, Hiemstra identifies illegalization as a governmental technique where "the illegalization of migrants creates various forms of value for the host country government and population, showing how illegality is central to neoliberal capitalist political and economic systems" (Hiemstra, 2024, p. 802).

Migrant Body Commodification

Martin (2020) extends this analysis to U.S. immigration detention, documenting how private prison corporations extract profit directly from detained migrants' bodies. The detention bed quota transforms migrants into guaranteed revenue streams for corporations operating detention facilities through Congressional mandates. Martin introduces status value, arguing legal categorization makes migrants "valuable in their excludability, detainability and inability to legally support themselves" (Martin, 2020, p. 747), enabling commodification of biological processes where "eating, washing, staying warm, caring for others" become contracted services priced as "bed space" and "bed days" (Martin, 2020, p. 748).

Morris (2024a) theorizes "extractive asylum": the transformation of asylum systems into mechanisms for extracting value from refugee bodies. Analyzing Nauru's offshore detention, Morris demonstrates how asylum seekers "substitut[e] phosphate as a new human commodity" (Morris, 2024a, p. 128). Drawing on Kathryn Yusoff's theorization of racial capitalism's geological foundations, Morris argues refugee bodies function as extractable units: "Bodies become gold, emptied of the sign of the human, reinvested with the signification of units of energy and properties of extraction" (Morris, 2024a, p. 130). Each body produces revenue for detention contractors, employment for case workers, research opportunities, fundraising appeals, and political legitimacy for governments performing humanitarian obligations.

The racial dimensions of corporeal commodification prove essential to understanding its operation. Robinson (1983) demonstrates that racial capitalism extracts value not despite but through the racialized devaluation of certain populations. Bodies become exploitable precisely through their marking as less than human. The specific targeting of Venezuelan

migrants in contemporary U.S. enforcement exemplifies this logic: nationality, legal precarity, and racialized assumptions about deservingness converge to render these bodies appropriable in ways that would prove politically impossible for other populations. As Melamed (2015) argues, contemporary racial capitalism operates through differential inclusion that simultaneously incorporates and exploits racialized populations, rendering them essential to yet extractable within neoliberal governance structures.

Parry's (2012) concept of "incomplete commodification" proves valuable for analyzing how bodies move into and out of commodity states during their circulation, revealing unstable boundaries between humanitarian discourse and systematic value extraction.

The Untheorized Body

While this scholarship demonstrates that illegality enables diverse value extraction, it has not theorized how the migrant body itself operates as the fundamental commodity form enabling extraction across the full spectrum of enforcement practices. Vogt's (2013) documentation of Mexico's "cachuco industry" reveals systematic commodification through criminal networks operating largely outside legal frameworks. This article examines a distinct phenomenon: state-sanctioned commodification by U.S. governmental actors themselves operating with legal legitimacy that establishes replicable templates.

What remains untheorized is how the migrant body, can be moved through space, confined in space, and made visible or invisible through spatial strategies, constitutes the commodity form enabling these diverse value extraction mechanisms across different enforcement modalities. The body becomes the unit of account in a political economy of immigration enforcement where value accrues not primarily from migrant labor but from governmental capacity to move, confine, display, and remove migrant bodies in ways serving multiple overlapping political and economic agendas.

Building on Vogt's (2013) demonstration of corporeal commodification in transit contexts, Morris's (2024a) theorization of bodies as extractable units in asylum systems, Martin's (2020) analysis of status value in detention economies, and Hiemstra's (2024) documentation of spatial value differentiation, this article develops a comprehensive framework for understanding migrant body commodification across the full spectrum of enforcement practices.

Defining Migrant Body Commodification

Migrant body commodification is the process through which state actors convert migrants' physical bodies into quantifiable units of extractable value that can be strategically positioned in space to generate economic, political, diplomatic, and symbolic capital. This differs fundamentally from labor commodification, which extracts value from migrants' work, and from the general exploitation enabled by illegality. Migrant body commodification specifically describes how state power treats the migrant body itself as the fundamental commodity whose spatial positioning, visibility, and legal status can be manipulated to produce diverse value streams accruing directly to governmental actors.

The migrant body functions as a commodity through three essential properties. First, calculability: each body represents a quantifiable unit whose value can be measured, optimized, and compared using standard metrics. Abbott's Texas program calculated per-body transportation costs at \$1,451, while DeSantis's Martha's Vineyard operation achieved per-capita costs of \$12,812, demonstrating bodies as discrete accounting units subject to

cost-benefit analysis. Second, spatial manipulability: bodies can be moved through space, confined in specific locations, or displaced to strategic destinations to maximize extractable value. The deliberate selection of Martha's Vineyard as destination, or CECOT as detention site, reveals spatial positioning as value optimization strategy. Third, legal fungibility: migrants' precarious legal status renders their bodies available for appropriation without the consent requirements or due process protections that would constrain similar treatment of citizens.

These properties enable what we term optimization logics: strategic frameworks for extracting maximum value from migrant bodies across different operational contexts. As the following cases demonstrate, state actors deploy distinct optimization strategies, analogous to financial market instruments, to convert legal precarity into calculable returns serving governmental objectives.

Methodology

This research examines migrant body commodification through systematic analysis of three cases: Governor Abbott's interstate busing operations (2022-2024), Governor DeSantis's migrant flight operations (2022-2023), and the Trump administration's CECOT transnational detention arrangement (2025). The methodology combines government expenditure records, political campaign documentation, facility operational data, diplomatic communications, and media coverage to quantify different forms of value extraction.

Primary documentation included state expenditure records from the Texas Division of Emergency Management and Florida Department of Emergency Management, State Department statements and congressional testimony transcripts for the CECOT case, and corporate contractor databases revealing private sector networks benefiting from commodification. Political value extraction claims were verified through campaign finance reports, media analysis, and administration officials' public statements. Each quantified extraction figure was confirmed through at least three independent sources, prioritizing official government reports, state audit documentation, and court filings.

The methodology acknowledges limitations including classified diplomatic communications that remain inaccessible and privacy protections that limit individual migrant tracking across systems. Political value calculations necessarily involve proxy measures, as political capital resists precise monetary quantification. The cost-benefit analyses presented should be understood as illustrative demonstrations of commodification logic rather than empirically precise measurements. Nevertheless, the patterns revealed across cases demonstrate systematic treatment of migrant bodies as calculable commodity units subject to value optimization strategies.

Abbott's Systematic Commodification: The Industrial Model

Between April 2022 and January 2024, Texas Governor Greg Abbott's administration transported 102,000 migrants to Northern cities through a \$148 million program that diverted funds from the state prison system (Brooks Harper, 2022). This industrial-scale operation represents systematic commodification operating through what financial markets term index fund investing: acquiring large volumes of standardized commodity units for stable, long-term returns rather than spectacular gains. The program treated migrant bodies as fungible units specified by legal status (asylum seekers) and nationality (primarily

Venezuelan), with individual identity irrelevant to value extraction. This fungibility precisely characterizes commodity markets trading corn futures or crude oil contracts.

The exchange mechanism operated through two linked markets. First, Abbott's state government purchased circulation capacity at \$1,451 per migrant body through operational expenditures covering bus charters, coordination, and logistics (Collier, 2024). Second, Abbott converted this capital investment into political returns by strategically positioning bodies to generate media coverage, pressure Democratic jurisdictions, and activate Republican donor networks. The migrant body functioned as capital good, raw material purchased for processing into political output, rather than consumer good used directly by the purchaser.

Index fund investing provides precise analogy: accepting modest per-unit returns in exchange for stability through diversified positions across broad market sectors. Abbott's program operationalized this strategy by transporting migrants to Washington DC, New York City, Chicago, and Philadelphia (Collier, 2024), creating sustained pressure across multiple Democratic jurisdictions rather than concentrated symbolic strikes. The distributed targeting exemplifies index fund logic: diversified exposure reducing risk while generating consistent returns.

New York Mayor Eric Adams characterized this as targeting "five cities run by Black mayors," acknowledging that "this crisis is more than one city can handle" (New York City Mayor's Office, 2023). Abbott's 102,000-body volume enabled market dominance impossible for governors lacking equivalent border access (and access to bodies) or political will to operationalize systematic circulation at this scale.

Abbott leveraged the program for sustained national media visibility, with regular Fox News appearances on programs including Hannity and The Ingraham Angle (Texas Governor's Office, 2022; Astudillo et al., 2022). On at least one September 2022 occasion, Fox News cameras were pre-positioned to film migrant arrivals at Vice President Harris's residence, suggesting operational coordination between state enforcement and conservative media infrastructure (Amato, 2022). The sustained visibility positioned Abbott as a definitive Republican border security leader, attracting investment from conservative mega-donors focused on immigration politics (Ellis et al., 2024).

The systematic model's template replication value materialized when Arizona Governor Doug Ducey and Florida Governor Ron DeSantis launched similar programs (Chishti & Gelatt, 2022), demonstrating how successful commodification strategies propagate across political markets. This replication proves systematic commodification's stability: unlike spectacle operations dependent on specific actors and favorable timing, the systematic approach establishes bureaucratic infrastructure capable of sustained operations resistant to shifting political conditions.

Abbott's innovation extends existing frameworks in significant ways. Where Martin (2020) analyzes value extraction through detention confinement, Abbott extracts value through circulation itself. Each transported body represents calculable political capital measured in media coverage, donor activation, and jurisdictional pressure rather than detention bed-days. The program operationalizes what Hiemstra (2024) identifies as illegality's dual value production, generating sociopolitical legitimation through what Mountz and Hiemstra (2014) term "manufactured crisis" while extracting no direct economic value from migrant labor. The systematic model's durability, sustaining operations across multiple years despite legal challenges, demonstrates how commodification produces stable returns by normalizing exceptional measures into bureaucratic routine, transforming De Genova's (2010) "spectacle of enforcement" into industrial process.

The program's \$148 million expenditure to transport 102,000 migrants yields base operational cost of \$1,451 per body (Collier, 2024). However, this dramatically understates value generation when considering political capital produced. Using conservative proxies including estimated media exposure value and attributed fundraising increases, the operation generated approximately \$49 million in calculable political returns, representing 33% return on investment, or \$480 in political value per migrant body. This calculation demonstrates commodification logic rather than precise measurement, as political capital resists exact quantification. The figure excludes returns that cannot be monetized: enhanced Republican Party leadership positioning, template replication value, and sustained pressure forcing Democratic jurisdictions to expend municipal resources.

DeSantis's Spectacle Commodification: The Event Model

Florida Governor Ron DeSantis's migrant flight operations represent spectacle commodification operating through what financial markets term options trading: concentrated speculative bets on volatile political outcomes where success depends critically on market timing and sentiment. His \$12 million program pursued asymmetric risk-reward profiles, limited downside exposure with theoretically unlimited upside potential, through strategic symbolic targeting. Like options traders accepting total loss risk for chances at exponential returns, DeSantis invested in concentrated positions that would either generate extraordinary per-capita value or expire worthless depending on whether political market conditions aligned favorably.

DeSantis's September 2022 Martha's Vineyard operation represents spectacle commodification's optimal execution: concentrated symbolic targeting when market conditions favor spectacular returns. On September 14, 2022, Florida chartered two planes transporting 48 Venezuelan migrants from San Antonio, Texas to Martha's Vineyard, Massachusetts (Bump, 2022). The destination selection exemplified premium market positioning. Martha's Vineyard, a wealthy Democratic island accessible only by air or boat, summer haven for liberal elites including the Obamas, was chosen for symbolic resonance with conservative audiences as representing liberal hypocrisy on immigration. DeSantis paid Vertol Systems \$615,000, equivalent to \$12,812 per migrant body, for this concentrated position (Rosenzweig et al., 2022). Planes landed on the island without prior coordination to maximize shock value.

The operation achieved extraordinary media saturation exceeding any Abbott bus operation, with Google Trends showing searches for "Martha's Vineyard" reaching maximum historical popularity. DeSantis received standing ovations at Republican rallies within days. Conservative radio host Dana Loesch characterized it as "one of the most savvy political moves I've ever seen in my lifetime" (Loesch, 2024). The symbolic targeting activated conservative base audiences through cultural resonance around liberal hypocrisy themes, with the 48-body scale enabling clear narrative construction treating migrants as concentrated symbolic currency rather than ongoing infrastructure.

DeSantis, then positioning himself as potential presidential nominee, generated media value difficult to replicate through conventional campaign spending. Florida's \$615,000 expenditure for 48 migrants, yielding \$12,812 per body, achieved extraordinary efficiency through symbolic targeting. Using conservative proxies for media exposure value, fundraising activation, and enhanced campaign positioning, the operation theoretically generated \$6.2 million in political returns: 908% return on investment, or \$129,000 per migrant body (Rosenzweig et al., 2022). This 269-fold premium over Abbott's systematic

model (\$480 per body) demonstrates spectacle commodification's theoretical logic: concentrating resources on symbolic targeting generates dramatically higher per-unit returns when market conditions align favorably.

Options contracts in financial markets command higher premiums for volatility exposure because they provide asymmetric payoff structures: limited loss (the premium paid) but potentially unlimited gains if underlying conditions move favorably. DeSantis's concentrated positioning justified extraordinary per-unit costs through potential for exponential returns. The asymmetry proves crucial: while Abbott's systematic approach generates modest but predictable returns regardless of short-term conditions, DeSantis pursued volatility plays accepting total loss risk for chances at extraordinary gains.

DeSantis's June 2023 Sacramento flights demonstrate spectacle commodification's volatility when market conditions shift. Nine months after Martha's Vineyard, his presidential campaign had faltered. Despite transporting 36 migrants to Sacramento using identical operational frameworks, the operation generated negative returns. Media coverage framed it as desperate stunt; Trump campaign spokesperson Jason Miller belittled DeSantis as "the Fisher Price version of President Trump" (Bernal & Manchester, 2023); California Attorney General Rob Bonta signaled intent to bring charges (Bollag, 2023).

The nine-month shift fundamentally altered extractable value from identical operations. Martha's Vineyard occurred when DeSantis possessed ascendant positioning; Sacramento occurred after his devalued political standing. When DeSantis became a devalued political commodity, his spectacle operations expired worthless, revealing this model's core volatility: extraordinary returns when market sentiment aligns favorably, total losses when conditions shift.

The contrasting outcomes expose spectacle commodification's critical limitation compared to systematic approaches. Where Abbott's volume-based model proves resilient to shifting political conditions through diversification and sustained operations, DeSantis's concentrated symbolic bets depend entirely on favorable market timing. The volatility proves the commodification thesis: identical operations produced opposite returns based solely on market conditions (media narratives, campaign positioning, actor legitimacy) rather than migrants' inherent humanity.

Comparative Analysis: Optimization Flexibility and Shared Foundations

The 269-fold difference in per-capita political value extraction (\$480 per migrant body in Abbott's industrial model versus \$129,000 in DeSantis's Martha's Vineyard operation) demonstrates that identical migrant bodies generate vastly different returns depending on strategic deployment of their legal precarity and spatial positioning. This variability itself constitutes crucial evidence that contemporary immigration enforcement treats migrants as calculable commodity units whose value can be optimized, measured, and compared using standard political economy metrics. The fundamental distinction between these models lies not in whether they commodify migrant bodies but in how they extract value from the same underlying resource: migrants rendered exploitable through their illegalized status.

These models function as complementary rather than contradictory strategies. Abbott's systematic stability serves different governmental objectives than DeSantis's spectacular volatility, analogous to how institutional investors maintain both index fund positions (for stable growth) and options positions (for asymmetric upside exposure) within diversified

portfolios. Both approaches prove that migrant bodies constitute calculable commodities subject to value optimization, with choice of optimization strategy depending on available resources, political positioning, and risk tolerance.

Despite their operational differences, both models depend entirely on the same foundational mechanism identified by De Genova (2002): the production of migrant "illegality" as "a spatialized and typically racialized social condition" that renders migrants systematically vulnerable to exploitation. Neither Abbott's buses nor DeSantis's flights could extract value from migrants possessing secure legal status, meaningful consent rights, or effective access to judicial protection. The programs succeeded precisely because, as Hiemstra (2024) argues, illegality enables "various forms of value for the host country government and population" by creating populations who can be moved, confined, displayed, and deployed without the constraints that protect citizens' bodily autonomy. As Bosniak (2006) demonstrates, citizenship's protective capacity operates primarily through exclusion: defining who does not possess rights against state coercion, rendering migrant bodies available for involuntary circulation.

The domestic commodification models establish both operational templates and political precedents crucial for understanding transnational extensions. Abbott demonstrated that sustained, systematic processing of migrant bodies through spatial displacement infrastructure can generate consistent political returns while resisting legal challenges through normalization. DeSantis proved that spectacular symbolic operations can achieve extraordinary per-capita value extraction when political conditions align favorably. Most significantly, both models demonstrated that Republican executives could convert migrants' legal precarity into extractable political value through strategic spatial manipulation while successfully defying judicial oversight.

The CECOT Arrangement: Convergent Commodification Through Transnational Carceral Infrastructure

In March 2025, the Trump administration operationalized an arrangement that transcended both the systematic and spectacle approaches examined in domestic transportation programs. Invoking the Alien Enemies Act of 1798, a wartime authority unused since World War II, the administration deported approximately 250 Venezuelan migrants to El Salvador's Terrorism Confinement Center (CECOT), a maximum-security prison where they were held incommunicado for four months before eventual release through prisoner exchange with Venezuela. What distinguishes the CECOT operation is not simply its transnational dimension but the transparency with which administration officials articulated commodification logic that domestic operations typically obscure.

When Department of Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem visited CECOT on March 26, 2025, she characterized the facility as a deterrent 'tool,' stating it was 'one of the tools in our toolkit that we will use if you commit crimes against the American people' (Noem, 2025). This statement becomes more significant given that the Trump administration possessed documented knowledge that torture occurred systematically at CECOT when Noem delivered these words. The U.S. Department of State's 2023 Country Reports on Human Rights Practices for El Salvador concluded there was strong reason to believe torture was occurring inside the Salvadoran prison system, including CECOT (U.S. Department of State, 2023). Her characterization of a documented torture facility as a deterrent instrument

constituted an explicit threat: unauthorized entry could result in torture at a location whose conditions the United States had already documented.

The CECOT arrangement generated value across multiple simultaneous and sequential dimensions unavailable to domestic operations. Where Abbott's systematic approach extracted sustained political capital through volume processing and DeSantis's spectacle model achieved concentrated media impact through symbolic targeting, CECOT enabled extraction across diplomatic, institutional precedent, deterrent spectacle, and ultimately exchange value streams. The same detained bodies that Noem displayed in March as enforcement warnings became diplomatic currency in July when Secretary of State Marco Rubio negotiated their exchange for ten American prisoners held in Venezuela (U.S. Department of State, 2025). This sequential redeployment of identical human units across distinct value extraction mechanisms reveals sophisticated governmental calculation about how legal precarity unlocks extractable worth from migrant bodies themselves.

Engineering Legal Precarity Through Wartime Authority

The operation began on March 14-15, 2025, when President Trump invoked the Alien Enemies Act against Tren de Aragua, a Venezuelan criminal organization the administration designated as a "foreign terrorist organization" despite U.S. intelligence assessments finding no evidence of coordination with the Venezuelan government. Within 24 hours, the administration executed three flights transporting over 260 Venezuelan migrants to CECOT, defying a federal court order from Judge James Boasberg attempting to halt the deportations (American Immigration Council, 2025).

This manufactured legal emergency enabled the administration to bypass constitutional protections governing deportation proceedings. Many transported individuals were in the middle of asylum cases pending for months. They had undergone initial credible fear screenings, received work permits, and established lives in the United States while awaiting immigration court hearings. The Alien Enemies Act invocation converted these individuals from asylum seekers with pending legal claims into enemy combatants subject to wartime removal powers, fundamentally restructuring their legal status to enable commodification.

The administration's gang membership allegations collapsed under scrutiny. A CBS News investigation analyzed government documentation for the 238 Venezuelans and found that 75% had no apparent criminal records in either the United States or Venezuela (Vega, 2025). Immigration agents flagged tattoos as gang symbols without considering alternative explanations. Andry Hernandez Romero, a 31-year-old gay Venezuelan makeup artist and theater performer who fled persecution, was identified through Time magazine photographer Philip Holsinger's images being beaten and forcibly shaved upon arrival at CECOT. His attorney confirmed he had no criminal record in either country (Holsinger, 2025; Vega, 2025).

By deploying wartime authority against an alleged gang rather than enemy nation, the administration created a novel category of stateless enemies defined by organizational affiliation rather than nationality, enabling it to strip asylum protections through security framework recategorization.

CECOT as Commodification Infrastructure and Spectacle Performance

The selection of CECOT as receiving facility was strategically calculated to maximize multiple forms of value extraction. El Salvador's Terrorism Confinement Center, constructed under Bukele's mass incarceration campaign, has been documented by human rights organizations as a site of systematic torture (Human Rights Watch & Cristosal, 2025). The facility's notorious reputation amplified the Trump administration's messaging about tough enforcement while creating conditions preventing effective legal challenges. Critically, the administration possessed explicit documentation of these conditions from its own State Department reporting two years prior (U.S. Department of State, 2023).

The \$6 million payment provided direct economic value to El Salvador while positioning Bukele as a key Trump administration ally, with his April 2025 White House visit leveraging the arrangement into broader diplomatic capital.

For the migrants themselves, CECOT represented a spatial and legal black hole designed to prevent outside intervention. New York Times reporting based on interviews with 40 former detainees documented systematic abuse meeting the United Nations' definition of torture (Turkewitz et al., 2025). Throughout the four-month period, detained men had no contact with family members, attorneys, or consular officials. The geographic distance from U.S. courts, combined with jurisdictional ambiguities about which nation's laws applied, created conditions where migrants existed in legal suspension while serving as extractable commodities across multiple value streams.

Secretary Noem's March 2025 visit to CECOT exemplifies how transnational arrangements enable federal performance extracting value across multiple simultaneous dimensions. Given the administration's documented knowledge of systematic torture at CECOT, her characterization of the facility as a "tool" and potential "consequence" for unauthorized entry constituted an explicit threat of torture at a location whose conditions the United States had already documented.

The jurisdictional circumstances of her visit reveal strategic ambiguity. Once migrants were transferred to El Salvador, custody arrangements fell under State Department authority rather than the Department of Homeland Security (Turkewitz et al., 2025). Yet Noem, as DHS Secretary, traveled to CECOT and delivered authoritative policy pronouncements despite having no official capacity in the post-transfer arrangement. This ability to claim authority for spectacle value extraction while bearing no formal responsibility for detention conditions represents jurisdictional arbitrage operating within the federal government itself.

Noem's performance extracted value across multiple simultaneous dimensions. Her warning that CECOT represents "one of the consequences you could face" explicitly articulated detained bodies as deterrent messages to potential migrants, with documented torture amplifying the deterrent threat. Her public praise for President Bukele extracted diplomatic value by legitimizing the authoritarian partnership. Her framing of detainees as "terrorists" extracted narrative value justifying the operation to domestic audiences. Most significantly, her declaration of CECOT as a "tool in our toolkit" extracted institutional precedent value, signaling to other authoritarian governments that the United States views carceral-spatial partnerships, including those involving torture facilities, as available policy instruments.

The Prisoner Exchange: Bodies as Diplomatic Currency

The July 18, 2025 prisoner exchange revealed both the ultimate commodification logic underlying the CECOT arrangement and the capacity for detained bodies to generate value across multiple sequential extractions. The 252 Venezuelan migrants held at CECOT were

exchanged for ten American citizens and permanent residents detained in Venezuelan prisons, along with the release of an undetermined number of Venezuelan political prisoners (U.S. Department of State, 2025). Secretary of State Marco Rubio framed the exchange as diplomatic triumph, declaring "Until today, more Americans were wrongfully held in Venezuela than any other country in the world" and crediting President Trump's leadership (Rubio, 2025). This transaction represented the purest form of migrant body commodification: literal exchange value in which individual human beings were assigned calculable worth as diplomatic currency.

The prisoner swap demonstrates that the same bodies generated value across distinct extraction streams throughout their detention arc. Initially, these Venezuelans were instrumentalized for deterrent spectacle value through March deportation flights and Noem's subsequent performance. Four months later, those same bodies were redeployed for diplomatic exchange value. This sequential extraction from identical commodity units reveals sophisticated calculation: bodies were selected not only for immediate deterrent impact but for potential future exchange utility.

The transaction exposed deception in prior administration claims about custody and control. For months following March deportations, US officials insisted they had relinquished authority over Venezuelan migrants and could not request their release from Salvadoran custody (Turkewitz et al., 2025). When the July exchange occurred, however, both governments seamlessly coordinated the transfer, revealing that claims of jurisdictional impossibility were strategic fictions maintaining leverage for negotiation and continued value extraction from the migrant bodies.

The conversion of individual migrants into exchangeable diplomatic units represents commodification at its most literal. Each Venezuelan held at CECOT became calculable currency in international negotiations. Rubio's framing positioned American prisoners as wrongfully detained while treating Venezuelan migrants as legitimate trade goods, reinforcing hierarchies of citizenship worth that justified commodification.

Venezuela's government simultaneously extracted its own value from the transaction. While releasing only ten American prisoners, Venezuela secured the return of 252 Venezuelan citizens, a ratio it could present domestically as diplomatic victory demonstrating leverage over the United States. Venezuela's government confirmed 252 citizens were being repatriated, with President Maduro arranging for family members to meet the men at Simón Bolívar International Airport (Alvarez & Sands, 2025). President Maduro's government framed the exchange as successful negotiation with a hostile power, extracting political legitimacy from its capacity to secure mass repatriation. The same migrant bodies thus generated value for three governments simultaneously: the United States converted them into diplomatic triumph and freed American citizens; El Salvador monetized them through detention fees and diplomatic capital; Venezuela leveraged them to demonstrate state capacity to protect nationals abroad and negotiate from strength despite international isolation. This convergent extraction across three sovereign governments reveals migrant body commodification's ultimate sophistication: identical bodies generating calculable returns across multiple simultaneous national political economies.

The prisoner exchange reveals intra-governmental coordination in value extraction across cabinet departments. Where DHS Secretary Noem extracted spectacle and deterrent value through her March visit despite lacking official custody authority, State Department leadership under Rubio extracted diplomatic exchange value through July negotiations. Different agencies claimed different value streams from the same detained population depending on what served departmental objectives. This flexibility demonstrates how

transnational arrangements enable federal agencies to treat migrant bodies as fungible assets deployable across multiple policy domains.

The prisoner swap outcome demonstrates that CECOT detention was never about permanent removal or terrorism containment despite administration rhetoric. The operation's structure suggests a governing logic centered on maintaining detention leverage until bodies could be exchanged for higher-value assets. The four months between March deportation and July exchange represent the period during which detained Venezuelans generated maximum extractable value: sufficient time for deterrent impact to register while providing negotiation window for diplomatic exchange (Turkewitz et al., 2025). This timeframe suggests sophisticated planning with detention duration calibrated to optimize value extraction across both spectacle and diplomatic dimensions.

Comparative Value Extraction: CECOT vs. Domestic Programs

The CECOT arrangement demonstrates how transnational commodification generates distinct forms of value unavailable through domestic operations. The CECOT model enabled simultaneous extraction across multiple value dimensions unavailable through domestic operations.

Diplomatic value materialized through negotiations with both El Salvador and Venezuela, positioning the Trump administration as effectively managing complex international relationships while securing American citizen releases. Institutional precedent value emerged through successful defiance of federal court orders, demonstrating executive branch willingness to prioritize enforcement over judicial oversight. Template replication value was created by establishing CECOT as a proven model for offshore detention arrangements with authoritarian governments possessing carceral-spatial infrastructure willing to lease capacity to the United States.

Most significantly, the CECOT arrangement achieved what domestic programs could not: complete removal of migrants from U.S. legal jurisdiction while maintaining them in detention conditions serving U.S. political objectives. By removing migrants from domestic legal frameworks, the administration eliminated judicial oversight that had constrained Abbott's busing operations and DeSantis's flights. By distributing responsibility across three sovereign governments, the arrangement created conditions where no single authority bore clear accountability for detention conditions. And by maintaining the operation across only four months, the administration maximized deterrent and diplomatic value while minimizing the period during which legal challenges could develop.

Theorizing Migrant Body Commodification: Mechanisms and Governmental Rationality

Mechanisms of Commodification: From Systematic to Convergent

Migrant body commodification operates through three interrelated mechanisms that function with increasing sophistication across the systematic, spectacle, and transnational models. First, spatial manipulation transforms migrants' enforced mobility into political and economic capital. Abbott's systematic circulation generated sustained jurisdictional pressure; DeSantis's concentrated displacement created symbolic spectacle; CECOT's offshore detention enabled complete removal from domestic legal oversight. Second, jurisdictional engineering manipulates legal and administrative boundaries to maximize

extractable value while minimizing constraints. Abbott exploited interstate jurisdictional tensions; DeSantis targeted symbolic jurisdictions for maximum cultural resonance; CECOT manufactured three-nation complexity enabling each state to extract distinct value while claiming limited responsibility. Third, calculability and optimization treat migrant bodies as units whose value can be measured, compared, and strategically deployed. All three models demonstrate quantified per-capita costs, explicit return-on-investment calculations, and strategic adjustments based on political market conditions.

The three cases reveal distinct optimization strategies analogous to financial market instruments. Systematic commodification (Abbott's model) resembles index fund investing: diversified, volume-based exposure generating modest per-capita returns distributed across extended timelines. Abbott's \$148 million investment transported 102,000 migrants at \$1,451 per body, extracting stable political capital through sustained operations across multiple cities. The index fund approach accepts lower per-unit returns in exchange for reduced volatility, with diversified positions proving resilient to shifting short-term conditions.

Spectacle commodification (DeSantis's model) mirrors options trading: concentrated, timing-dependent bets pursuing extraordinary per-capita returns through symbolic events maximizing immediate media impact, demonstrating options trading's asymmetric payoff structure.

The CECOT arrangement functions like complex derivatives that create simultaneous exposure to multiple distinct markets through manufactured structural complexity. The three-nation architecture (U.S. legal authority claiming relinquishment, Salvadoran physical custody asserting U.S. control, Venezuelan diplomatic leverage over ultimate disposition) enabled each participating state to extract distinct value streams while maintaining plausible deniability about responsibility. This derivatives logic represents commodification's most sophisticated evolution: value derived from exploiting jurisdictional complexity itself rather than from simple asset ownership.

Most significantly, the CECOT case reveals sequential value extraction as a defining characteristic of advanced commodification. The same detained bodies generated spectacle value through March deportation flights and DHS Secretary Noem's performance at CECOT, then were redeployed four months later for diplomatic exchange value when Secretary of State Rubio negotiated their trade for American prisoners. This sequential extraction from identical commodity units demonstrates that transnational arrangements enable migrants to be "spent" multiple times across different value dimensions, achieving what domestic operations cannot: convergent commodification operating simultaneously across diplomatic, political, deterrent, institutional, and exchange value streams.

Theoretical Contribution: Toward a Framework of Migrant Body Commodification

This framework advances migration scholarship by theorizing the migrant body as a generalized commodity form whose strategic spatial positioning generates extractable value across diverse enforcement modalities. While previous scholarship documents specific extraction mechanisms (Martin's (2020) detention bed-days, Morris's (2024) asylum extraction, Vogt's (2013) transit commodification), this analysis reveals how a unified governmental rationality organizes apparently distinct enforcement operations around body commodification's logic.

This framework extends De Genova's insights about deportability by demonstrating what might be termed post-deportation commodification: value extraction that persists beyond and through removal itself, converting deportation from disciplinary threat into diplomatic resource. Where De Genova establishes that deportability functions as a spatial governance technology to discipline migrants through perpetual removal threat, the CECOT arrangement reveals how actual deportation creates new value streams unavailable when migrants remain in domestic circulation. The framework synthesizes across Hiemstra's (2024) demonstration that illegality produces dual value (economic exploitation and sociopolitical legitimization), Morris's (2024) theorization of bodies as extractable units, and Martin's (2020) analysis of status value, extending these insights transnationally to reveal how offshore arrangements enable value extraction mechanisms impossible within domestic legal constraints.

Recognizing migrant body commodification as the organizing logic unifying apparently distinct enforcement practices explains why contemporary immigration systems proliferate despite manifest inefficiency at preventing unauthorized migration. Across these cases, border control appears secondary to the continuous generation of commodifiable migrant bodies whose legal precarity enables systematic value extraction. Abbott's buses, DeSantis's flights, and the CECOT arrangement share no coherent immigration management rationale. Their only coherent logic is extraction: treating migrants as quantifiable units whose circulation through space generates calculable returns for state actors.

Conclusion

This analysis demonstrates that migrant body commodification functions as governmental rationality organizing diverse enforcement practices around a unified objective: optimizing extractable value from bodies rendered exploitable through legal precarity. The fact that similar migrants generated radically different returns depending on operational architecture demonstrates that contemporary enforcement treats migrants as calculable commodities subject to strategic deployment and optimization. The 269-fold difference in per-capita value extraction (\$480 per body in Abbott's systematic model versus \$129,000 in DeSantis's Martha's Vineyard operation) proves that enforcement's logic centers on value optimization rather than immigration management.

The three models represent not the limits of commodification but its current evolution. Abbott demonstrated that sustained volume processing generates stable political returns resilient to shifting conditions. DeSantis proved spectacular symbolic targeting can achieve extraordinary per-body efficiency when political market sentiment aligns favorably. The Trump administration showed that transnational arrangements enable sequential value extractions unavailable through domestic operations: the same bodies generating spectacle value through visible deportation and detention, then diplomatic exchange value through calculated trade for American prisoners.

The implications extend beyond academic theorizing. Recognizing commodification as enforcement's organizing logic reveals why reform efforts focused on humanitarian concerns or due process protections consistently fail to restrain these operations. State actors pursuing commodification objectives have no incentive to provide dignity, legal protection, or humane treatment when such provisions would constrain the spatial manipulation and legal abandonment that enable value extraction. The CECOT arrangement established templates for offshore detention cooperation with authoritarian governments possessing torture infrastructure, demonstrating that governmental rationality now openly calculates migrant suffering as policy input rather than humanitarian concern.

What unites these apparently distinct operations is their shared commitment to treating migrant bodies not as human subjects with rights and dignity but as raw material for state power's exercise. Each bus departure, each chartered flight, each offshore detention represents a calculated transaction where legal precarity gets converted into extractable value through spatial manipulation of bodies.

Conflict of Interest Statement

The author declares no conflicts of interest regarding this research.

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